

A FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY GUIDE

The Christian Spiritual Reset

*A 3-Day Guided Retreat to Overcome Burnout,
Hear God Clearly, and Renew Your Faith*

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FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY

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SESSION SEVEN

Listening for God's Direction

Day 3, morning (or after Session Five, if you did that this morning; take a proper break between them)

Before you begin

Good morning. This is the last day, and its shape is different from the first two. Day 1 was about arriving. Day 2 was about releasing and telling the truth. Day 3 turns outward again: listening, remembering who you are, and preparing to return. The heavier work is behind you, and if some of it is unfinished, that is expected and permitted.

This session is about listening. Before you start, reread the paragraph in Chapter 5 called "A word about hearing from God," because everything in this session depends on it. Whatever you sense today will be written down and tested. Unless immediate safety requires action, no major, irreversible, or high-risk decision is made during a retreat.

Central passage

1 Kings 19:9–18

Read it twice. The second time, notice that God's response includes both correction and provision.

Teaching

We have been following Elijah since Chapter 1, and this is where his story arrives. Strengthened by the food God provided, Elijah travelled forty days and nights until he reached Horeb, the mountain closely associated with Moses and Israel's covenant history, and he entered a cave. God's first words to him are a question: "What are you doing here, Elijah?"

Elijah's answer reflects both genuine danger and a perception narrowed by isolation: he believes he is the only faithful one left, and that they seek his life. Then God tells him to stand on the mountain, and there is a wind that tears rocks apart, and an earthquake, and a fire, and the text says three times that the LORD was not in them. After the fire comes something the Hebrew describes with a phrase that is difficult to reproduce exactly; translations range from "a still small voice" and "a gentle whisper" to "a sound of sheer silence." Elijah hears it, covers his face, and goes to the mouth of the cave. And God asks the same question again: "What are you doing here, Elijah?"

Elijah gives the same answer, word for word. And then God speaks, and this is the part to notice. He does not give Elijah a full explanation or remove every threat. He gives direction involving two future kings and Elisha, Elijah's prophetic successor. He corrects the complaint: there are seven thousand in Israel who have not bowed to Baal; Elijah is not alone. And he sends him back the way he came. God's earlier care, the food and the sleep, is now joined by correction, companionship, and direction. Elijah receives work to do, a successor to share it, and the knowledge that the whole thing never depended on him.

I dwell on this because Christians often approach "hearing God" expecting something the passage does not show. We expect explanation, and God gave assignment. We expect to be told we

were right, and God gently showed Elijah that his picture was incomplete. And in this particular encounter, the dramatic signs are explicitly distinguished from the form in which the voice comes. The passage does not teach that God always speaks quietly; elsewhere Scripture portrays him speaking through thunder, fire, dreams, prophets, and public events. It teaches us not to equate spectacle with divine direction. Quiet may help us notice what noise obscures, but God is not limited to retreat conditions. Direction may become clearer through Scripture, counsel, ordinary responsibilities, circumstances, or time after the retreat.

One thing the passage does not teach is that correction is authenticated by how uncomfortable it feels. A self-critical person may trust the harshest thought because it feels humbling, and that is a mistake. God's correction is consistent with Scripture, truthful about sin, proportionate, directed toward repentance and life, and distinct from vague condemnation or self-hatred. Conviction identifies something that can be confessed or changed. Condemnation declares the whole person hopeless. If what you sense today sounds like the second, it is not the voice you are listening for.

Now, how does God speak? Christians commonly seek his guidance through Scripture, prayer, conscience, wise counsel, and careful attention to circumstances. Only Scripture functions as the church's authoritative written standard. **2 Timothy 3:16-17** says all Scripture is God-breathed and useful for teaching, reproof, correction, and training, so that God's people may be "complete, equipped for every good work." Most of what God has to say to you about how to live is already written, and a great deal of "seeking direction" is simply the search for something more exciting than obedience to what we already know. Before you

listen for anything new, ask what Scripture already says about the matter in front of you.

Every personal interpretation, impression, circumstance, and piece of counsel remains fallible and must be tested. The Holy Spirit may bring conviction, but not every feeling of guilt comes from the Spirit; conscience itself needs formation through Scripture, truth, community, and, where relevant, mental- health care. And even a genuine call may need another person to recognise it. Samuel, in **1 Samuel 3:1– 10**, heard God's voice three times and each time ran to Eli, assuming the old priest was calling. Eli was an imperfect man; the same book records his failures with his sons. Yet in that moment he gave Samuel a wise response, and told the boy what to say: "Speak, LORD, for your servant hears." Even in a time when the word of the Lord was rare, Samuel needed another person to help him interpret what was happening. You are not meant to do this alone. The retreat's insistence on a support person and on Part Five's testing is not a lack of faith in God's voice. It is Eli.

Here are the tests, which Chapter 5 introduced and Part Five will apply in detail.

- Does it agree with Scripture, read in context?
- Does it reflect the character and fruit of Christ?
- Is it truthful about facts, not merely feelings?
- Does it withstand time and careful questioning?
- What do mature and appropriately qualified advisers say?
- Does it respect safety, consent, justice, and accountability?
- Does it require secrecy, superiority, recklessness, or immunity from challenge?
- Is the proposed action proportionate and reversible?

- Are you sufficiently rested, regulated, informed, and supported to decide? Two things the tests are not. Urgency is a reason to slow down, unless immediate safety or a genuine external deadline requires action. And peace may accompany discernment, but it is not proof; people can feel peaceful about harmful decisions, and faithful action can feel frightening.

On responsibilities: does what you sense deal faithfully with legitimate responsibilities rather than using spiritual language to escape them? And does it also recognise that some roles, expectations, or relationships may need to change for reasons of truth, safety, justice, or health? Both questions are real, and Part Five will help you hold them together.

Two further cautions. First, if you hear a voice that others cannot hear, particularly one that issues commands, threatens you, or makes it hard to tell internal experience from external reality, do not assume it is God. End the retreat and seek prompt professional assessment. If a voice commands you to harm yourself or someone else, tells you that you have a unique world-saving mission, or makes you feel unable to remain safe, seek urgent professional or emergency help and do not remain alone. Second, if you listen and sense nothing at all, you have not failed. Chapter 12 said this. Faithful listening that hears nothing is still faithful, and God's direction may come later, through ordinary means, when you are back in ordinary life.

Self-assessment

In your journal:

1. God asked Elijah, "What are you doing here?" Answer it for yourself, honestly, in a few sentences. Not why you came, but what you are actually doing here, now, on the third morning.

2. In the past, what have you understood as God's guidance?
Looking back, what fruit, correction, confirmation, or later evidence helped you evaluate it?
3. Is there a decision, a direction, or a question you have been hoping this retreat would settle? Write it in one line.
4. What does Scripture already say about that matter, as far as you know? If you are not sure, write that down; it is the first thing to find out.

Guided prayer

Use only the lines that fit. Change or omit the others.

Speak, Lord, for your servant hears.

Here is what I am doing here: _____.

I am not asking only for comfort, or for permission.

I am asking for your direction, even where it corrects me.

Show me what your Word already says.

Give me the people I need to recognise your voice.

Whatever I sense today, I will write down and test, and

I will not act rashly.

If I hear nothing, I will trust you anyway.

Amen.

Silence

Suggested length: twenty minutes. This is the longest silence in the retreat. Adjust it to what you can manage; ten is a complete practice, and so is five.

Anchor phrase: **"Speak, Lord, for your servant hears."** Or, shorter: **"Here I am."**

This is a period of prayerful attention, not a message-detection exercise. Bring your one-line question before God, release the demand for an answer, and remain with the phrase. Do not chase an answer. A thought's vividness, repetition, emotional force, or sudden appearance does not make it divine; unwanted thoughts and images should not be treated as instructions or revelations. If something seems significant, write one or two neutral words on a card and return to the anchor. Recording it does not endorse it. If nothing comes, stay with the phrase. Attention is the practice; the outcome is not yours to produce.

When the timer ends, take one unhurried breath before moving. If you want to remain longer, you may; if you are ready to stop, stop.

Journaling

1. Write down, without editing, anything you sensed during the silence: a verse, a thought, a phrase, a picture, a direction, or nothing. Do not decide yet whether it was God.
2. Did anything seem corrective, encouraging, clarifying, or unresolved? Do not force one of these categories if nothing significant emerged.
3. For anything significant, go through the tests above and mark each one "supports," "raises concern," "not yet examined," or "requires qualified advice." Nothing is confirmed until those checks are complete, and several of them cannot be completed on a retreat.
4. Who is a mature, trustworthy Christian who knows Scripture, understands your situation, respects appropriate boundaries, and has no interest in controlling your decision? For medical, legal, financial, or abuse-related matters, who has the relevant competence? If you do not have such people, who could you begin to ask?

Practical exercise: listening with Scripture

This exercise uses a longstanding Christian practice: slow, prayerful attention to Scripture. It takes twenty to thirty minutes.

Choose a passage. If Scripture addresses your matter directly, study a substantial passage in context rather than searching for an isolated confirming verse; for complex decisions, note the broader biblical principles involved and seek informed guidance after the retreat. If your question is not one Scripture speaks to directly, choose one of these: Psalm 25:4–10, Proverbs 3:5–8, or James 1:5–8. Each is about seeking God's way.

Read the passage slowly, three times, with a pause between each reading.

After the first reading, notice which word or phrase stands out to you. Do not analyse why. Write it down.

After the second reading, ask what that word or phrase is saying in its own context, to its original hearers. Read the verses around it. If you do not know the historical or literary context, write "I need to study this" rather than guessing, and use a reliable study Bible or commentary after the retreat. Write a sentence.

After the third reading, ask what it might be saying to you, in your situation, in light of your question. Write that down too, and mark it clearly as *what I sense*, not *what God said*.

Then take an index card and write two things on it: **What I sense:** followed by your sentence, and **What I will test it against:** followed by the tests, and the names of the people you will consult. Keep this card with the Act, Share, and Seek-counsel cards from Session Three. It goes home with you. Part Five's first chapter is built around it.

Do not make a major, irreversible, high-risk, or life-altering decision solely on the basis of today's impression. Low-risk

actions already supported by Scripture and wisdom, such as arranging counsel, making a medical appointment, or gathering information, may be appropriate. Waiting is not unbelief. It acknowledges that our interpretation is fallible even when God is faithful. If an impression conflicts with Scripture, promotes harm, or cannot withstand truthful examination, do not treat it as divine direction. If it remains unclear, leave it unclear rather than forcing certainty.

Closing declaration

Read only what you can say honestly. Adjust the words if you need to.

God has spoken authoritatively in Scripture, and I will begin there.

I have brought my question honestly without demanding an immediate answer.

Any impression I recorded remains an impression until it has been tested.

I will seek wise and appropriately qualified counsel.

I will not use God's name to justify harm, haste, secrecy, or escape.

If faithful responsibility calls me back, I will respond with wisdom, safety, and support.

Notes

Space for anything else you want to record from this session.

After Session Seven: take a break, a meal, and a walk if you can. What follows depends on your capacity. Sessions Eight and Nine, on identity and purpose, are flex sessions: do one or both this afternoon only if you have the energy for them, and do not feel that Day 3 is incomplete without them. Many readers will move

straight from this break to Session Ten in the late afternoon, and finish the retreat well. Sessions Eight and Nine will be waiting in the 30-day plan. Whatever you choose, do not go into Session Ten tired; it deserves a settled hour.